

Saracoff Sentinel Team Tijuana

Taking out the Garbage

Spring 2007

We are rejoicing in the two ministries we have next to the garbage dump in Tijuana. Camino Vivo Club has seen some improvements. Chela and Salazar's wife work together in this Tijuana backwash to teach children to follow Christ and to encourage them to continue their studies at school. These children battle family pressures to spend all the time they can collecting recyclables from the garbage. A church from Solana Beach comes one Saturday a month to make breakfast for the children and to help build a home-work study room.

Chela has also started a club in an area on the other side of the dump called Carretas. The community leaders offered land where we can build a youth center. We need to fence in the land to hold it and then proceed with the process of leveling. A contractor has given us some retaining blocks to help and a church in Rancho Bernardo has made the first donation to start the work.

The city is planning a new garbage dump and we do not know what effect this will have on the people as the flow of garbage stops. Many of the houses are very minimal shelters. We may be able to help some via micro enterprise development. (See back page) Stopping the garbage provides an opportunity for those willing to change. They will have to develop new skills. The new situation hopefully will alleviate the pressure on the children. Sad to say, many will not want the garbage to leave their community. It's always hard to change and human nature tends to want to stay on the road it already knows. We all find it hard to leave the familiar. Is there some garbage in our lives we need to get rid of? Some new direction God wants us to go?



Prayer Requests:

- Volunteers to help level and build the new youth center.
- Team unity—**Chela** and **Francisca** are from two different church traditions and they need to give grace to each other so they can concentrate on the main task of reflecting Jesus to kids.
- **Francisco**, promising leader for micro-finance, faces discouraging setbacks.
- Pastor Mondragon's wife, **Magdalena**, faces imminent surgery for a tumor.
- New outreach to children in the "Zona Norte" (red light district); women from Esperanza Rehab are helping kids find Jesus sooner than they did.



What looks like a tranquil setting is really part of a smelly land-fill next to a corral of pigs who feed on garbage. But there are precious little ones here who are eager to know Jesus.

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How do we help the poor in Tijuana avoid a pitiful life looking for hand-outs and their children avoid repeating the cycle because they were never able to get an education? How do we help Mexico and also help our own country to keep from being over-run with illegal immigrants looking for jobs? How can we start to give ethics to a society over-run with corruption? What tool is available to Christianity at this hour? Could micro finance be a solution?

Micro Finance to the Rescue?



Our micro finance partner FIPS now has over 8,000 loans out to indigenous people in Oaxaca and Guanajuato (states in Mexico). Their goal is to double that number in the next year. FIPS is working with the Mexican government to help people start small businesses to bring them out of poverty and support their families.



Josefina's donut production got a boost from the micro finance loan. She runs a home for battered women.

This last year we have been struggling to start Micro Finance in Tijuana. This is harder than working with indigenous people in southern Mexico who have a natural group unity. Tijuana people are more transient, less trusting, and used to hand-outs instead of having people expecting them to work it on their own.

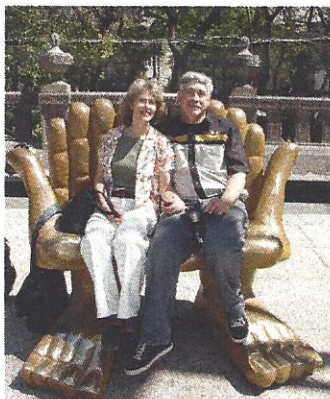
We just had our first group start a month ago and we were hoping to have a second group started this month. One of the main leaders of our first group got sued on a family matter right after this good beginning. The group is still holding together but has felt the impact. Then our second group also experienced a problem. The week it was to start, Tijuana experienced a downpour. Many of the group had houses on the side of a steep hill, the rain undermined their homes, and the government moved them to another area. Now we need more group members before we can start in that area. Our goal for Tijuana is to have 250 people with loans (or 12 groups of 20 people) by the end of the year.

We have the additional challenge of making the micro finance groups a vehicle of gospel witness. FIPS is a Mexican non profit that receives funds (from Mexico) so they cannot witness overtly. Even though FIPS cannot witness directly, groups can be eternally affected by Christians in the group or by godly businessmen (or women) who come to their weekly meetings to talk about how they can improve their businesses. The groups also have a 20 minute time in their meetings they can choose to have an elective such as classes in health or a Bible study. If they elect the latter then it is not a problem with the government since the group and not FIPS dictated it. We can also teach ethics of business which can be based on the Bible as long as we do not reference it to specific Bible verses.

Family news



Ian lent his energies to our LAM Mexico retreat by helping with the children's program. Jack and the other boys loved him!



Greg and Kathy agree that the best place is "in His hands."



Anna volunteered to host a delightful student from Australia in January. Fiona introduced us to "Vegemite" and joined a Tijuana team on Dia de los Reyes (1/6). She was "heaps fun."